

Absolutely — **egg** is a strong but relatively compact polysemy target because your passage uses it here:

> “They are especially known for their sourdough bread, **egg tarts**, and seasonal desserts.”

Here **egg** is part of the compound **egg tart**, referring to a tart with a custard-like filling made mainly from eggs, sugar, and milk/water. The word itself also has major meanings in **food**, **biology/reproduction**, **animal eggs generally**, plus useful extensions such as **nest egg** and **egg-shaped**.

Word family: **egg / egg-shaped / egghead**

Base word: egg

Plural: eggs

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / limited verb uses (較少見動詞)

Meaning in your passage: **egg** = edible egg used as food/ingredient — 蛋 ; 雞蛋

Your phrase:

> “**egg tarts**”

Here **egg** refers to:

> **an edible bird’s egg, especially a chicken egg, used as a main ingredient in the tart filling.**

繁體中文：

可食用的鳥蛋，尤其是雞蛋；此處指蛋撻餡料中的主要蛋類材料

Natural translation:

> “egg tarts”

「**蛋撻**」

So here:

> **egg** = 雞蛋 / 蛋類食材

1. **egg** = edible bird’s egg — 蛋 ; 雞蛋

The core everyday food meaning.

Practice 1 — Source

> “The bakery is famous for its **egg tarts**.”

「這間麵包店以**蛋撻**聞名。」

Practice 2

> “She had two **eggs** for breakfast.”

「她早餐吃了兩隻**雞蛋**。」

Practice 3

> “Add an egg to the mixture.”

「在混合物中加入一隻**雞蛋**。」

egg = 作為食物或烹飪材料使用的鳥蛋，日常通常默認雞蛋

2. **egg** = reproductive structure produced by birds, reptiles, fish, insects etc. — 卵；蛋

A major biological meaning.

Practice 4

> “The bird laid three **eggs**.”

「那隻鳥下了三隻**蛋**。」

Practice 5

> “The insect lays its eggs on leaves.”

「這種昆蟲把**卵**產在葉子上。」

egg = 動物產生、可發育成新個體的生殖結構

Natural Chinese varies:

* birds/reptiles → 蛋

* insects/fish → 卵

3. **egg** = female reproductive cell — 卵細胞

A more precise biological/medical sense.

Practice 6

> “An **egg** can be fertilized by a sperm cell.”

「**卵細胞**可以被精子受精。」

Practice 7

> “The ovaries release eggs.”

「卵巢會釋放**卵細胞**。」

egg — biology = 女性 / 雌性生殖細胞，即 ovum

This is more precise than the whole shell-covered bird egg.

4. **egg** = egg-shaped object/form — 卵形物；蛋形

A visual/shape extension.

Practice 8

> “The sculpture has the shape of an **egg**.”

「這座雕塑呈**蛋形 / 卵形**。」

Practice 9

> “The stone looked like a giant egg.”

「那塊石頭看起來像一隻巨大的**蛋**。」

egg = 因外形橢圓、圓潤而被比作蛋的物件

This is usually contextual rather than a fully separate dictionary core sense.

5. **egg-shaped** = 卵形的；蛋形的

A useful family extension.

Practice 10

> “The table has an **egg-shaped** top.”

「這張桌子的桌面是**卵形的**。」

Practice 11

> “They chose an egg-shaped lamp.”

「他們選了一盞**蛋形的燈**。」

egg-shaped = 外形像蛋一樣呈橢圓 / 卵形的

6. **egg** = spawn/roe in some food/biological contexts — 魚卵；卵

A contextual extension.

Practice 12

> “The fish laid thousands of **eggs**.”

「那條魚產下數千粒**魚卵**。」

Practice 13

> “Fish eggs are used in some cuisines.”

「有些菜系會使用**魚卵**。」

egg = 魚類等動物的卵

Important:

For prepared fish eggs as food, English may also use:

> **roe**

So **fish eggs** and **roe** overlap, but are not always identical in culinary register.

7. **nest egg = 儲備金；私房積蓄；退休積蓄**

A major figurative compound.

Practice 14

> “They saved a small **nest egg** for emergencies.”

「他們存了一筆小小的**應急儲備金**。」

Practice 15

> “She built up a nest egg for retirement.”

「她為退休累積了一筆**儲蓄**。」

****nest egg = 為未來用途逐步累積的一筆儲蓄 / 資金****

This is one of the most useful figurative extensions.

8. **egghead = 書呆子；知識分子型的人（非正式）**

A useful family extension with its own modern meaning.

Practice 16

> “He was teased for being an **egghead**.”

「他因為被人覺得像個**書呆子**而遭取笑。」

Practice 17

> “The discussion was full of policy eggheads.”

「討論裡都是一些政策方面的**學者型專家 / 書呆子型人物**。」

****egghead = 非正式地指非常學術、聰明或書卷氣重的人****

Register:

* informal

* can be teasing or mildly insulting

9. **good egg = 好人；可靠的人**

A somewhat old-fashioned but still recognizable idiom.

Practice 18

> “He’s a **good egg**.”

「他是個**好人 / 可靠的人**。」

Practice 19

> “She turned out to be a good egg.”

「結果發現她是個**挺好的人**。」

good egg = 性格好、可靠、討人喜歡的人

Register:

* informal

* somewhat old-fashioned/BrE-flavoured

This belongs in the idiom layer rather than a core bare-*egg* sense.

10. **bad egg = 壞人；麻煩人物**

The contrasting idiom.

Practice 20

> “He was considered a **bad egg**.”

「大家認為他是個**壞傢伙 / 麻煩人物**。」

Practice 21

> “One bad egg can cause problems for the whole team.”

「一個**麻煩人物**就可能令整個團隊出問題。」

bad egg = 品格差、麻煩或不可靠的人

Again:

- * idiomatic
- * informal
- * somewhat dated

11. **egg someone on** = 慫恿；煽動

This is a very common phrasal verb, but under our rule I'll **flag** rather than fully **curate** it.

> **egg someone on**

> = 慫恿 / 煽動某人做某事，通常是冒險、愚蠢或不好的事

Example:

> "His friends egged him on."

「他的朋友在旁邊**慫恿他**。」

Important:

This sense is historically unrelated to ordinary food **egg** in learners' minds, so it is excellent MCQ material, but it belongs in the phrasal-verb layer.

Important distinction: **egg** vs **chicken egg**

In everyday food contexts:

> **egg**

usually means:

> **chicken egg**

unless another animal is specified.

Examples:

> duck egg

> = 鴨蛋

> quail egg

> = 鵪鶉蛋

> fish egg

> = 魚卵

So in:

> “Add two eggs.”

the default interpretation is usually chicken eggs.

Important distinction: **egg** — food vs reproductive cell

Food:

> “I ate an egg.”

= 我吃了一隻雞蛋。

Biology:

> “The egg was fertilized.”

= 卵細胞被受精。

Same English word, but Chinese often needs a more precise distinction:

* 蛋

* 卵

* 卵細胞

Important distinction: **egg** vs **ovum**

egg

everyday/general biological word.

ovum

technical biological term:

= 卵細胞

> egg cell
> = 卵細胞

> ovum
> = 卵細胞，較正式 / 科學

Important distinction: **egg vs roe**

egg

general term for reproductive units.

roe

mass of fish eggs, especially in culinary/fishing contexts.

> fish eggs
> = 魚卵

> salmon roe
> = 三文魚籽 / 鮭魚卵

Roe is more specialized.

Important distinction: **egg vs spawn**

egg

individual eggs/ova.

spawn

eggs released by fish/amphibians, often as a mass; can also mean the act/result of spawning.

> frogspawn
> = 蛙卵

So:

> spawn ≠ simply one egg

Important distinction: **egg tart** vs **tart with egg**

Your source has the lexicalized compound:

> **egg tart**

= 蛋撻

This does **not** simply mean:

> any tart that happens to contain egg somewhere in the recipe.

It refers to a recognized pastry with an egg-custard filling.

So for database purposes:

> **egg tart** = 蛋撻

should be treated as a useful compound, not a new meaning of **egg**.

Important distinction: **egg-shaped** vs **oval**

egg-shaped

= specifically shaped like an egg, often broader at one end.

oval

= general elongated round shape.

So:

> egg-shaped object

> may be oval,

but not every oval is specifically egg-shaped.

Important distinction: **nest egg** vs **savings**

savings

general:

= 儲蓄

nest egg

specifically:

= 為未來用途保留 / 逐步累積的一筆錢

> retirement savings

> = 退休儲蓄

> a retirement nest egg

> = 為退休累積的一筆儲備金

Nest egg has a stronger sense of a protected reserve.

Important distinction: **egghead vs intelligent person**

intelligent person

neutral:

= 聰明的人

egghead

informal:

= 很學術 / 書卷氣重 / 像書呆子的聰明人

So **egghead** can carry:

* teasing

* dismissiveness

* affectionate humour

depending on context.

Important grammar note: **egg is countable**

Natural:

> an egg

> two eggs

> several eggs

Unlike:

> bread

which is normally uncountable.

This creates a useful bakery contrast:

> some bread

> two eggs

Important note on polysemy depth

****Egg**** has a compact but meaningful modern inventory.

The genuinely useful core senses are mainly:

1. ****edible egg****
2. ****animal reproductive egg****
3. ****egg cell / ovum****

Then the richest extensions are compounds and idioms:

- * egg-shaped
- * nest egg
- * egghead
- * good egg / bad egg
- * egg someone on

So we should ****not invent separate senses for fried egg, boiled egg, scrambled egg, egg tart, etc.****
Those are just culinary preparations/compounds.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern inventory includes:

- * ****egg — food**** = 蛋 / 雞蛋
- * ****egg — animal reproduction**** = 蛋 / 卵
- * ****egg — reproductive cell**** = 卵細胞
- * ****egg — shape reference**** = 蛋形 / 卵形

* **egg-shaped** = 卵形的
 * **fish eggs** = 魚卵
 * **nest egg** = 儲備金 / 積蓄
 * **egghead** = 書呆子 / 學者型人物
 * **good egg** = 好人
 * **bad egg** = 壞傢伙 / 麻煩人物
 * **egg someone on** = 慫恿 / 煽動 (片語層)

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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egg — food	作為食物 / 烹飪材料使用的鳥蛋，日常通常指雞蛋
egg — animal reproduction	動物產生、可發育成新個體的生殖結構
egg — cell	雌性生殖細胞；卵細胞
egg-shaped	外形像蛋一樣呈卵形 / 橢圓形的
fish eggs	魚類產生的卵；魚卵
nest egg	為未來用途逐步累積的一筆儲蓄 / 資金
egghead	非正式指非常學術、書卷氣重或聰明的人
good egg	非正式 / 較舊式指好人、可靠的人
bad egg	非正式 / 較舊式指品格差或麻煩的人

For your original phrase

> “They are especially known for their sourdough bread, **egg tarts**, and seasonal desserts.”

The exact meaning is:

egg = 作為蛋撻餡料主要材料的雞蛋；整個 compound **egg tart** 就是「蛋撻」。

Natural translation:

> **「他們尤其以酸種麵包、蛋撻和季節限定甜品而聞名。」**

The highest-value contrasts are:

- > **egg — food** → 雞蛋
- > **bird egg** → 鳥蛋
- > **insect egg** → 昆蟲卵
- > **egg cell** → 卵細胞
- > **egg-shaped** → 卵形的
- > **nest egg** → 儲備金 / 積蓄
- > **egghead** → 書呆子 / 學者型人物
- > **egg someone on** → 慫恿某人 (片語)